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FISH IN TROUBLED WATERS

The GOP-led House has voted to repeal protections for the longfin smelt, which they say make it harder to deliver water from the Sacramento-San Joaquin River Delta to farmers. **CALIFORNIA, B1**

Arab language network is latest casualty

Another U.S.-backed news outlet faces funding cut. This one has a history of woes.

By NABIH BULOS

AMMAN, Jordan — The message was contrite but direct. “I’m heartbroken. If you’re receiving this letter, I’m letting you go — effective immediately.”

The email came from Jeffrey Gedmin, head of Middle East Broadcasting Networks, or MBN, the non-profit overseeing the U.S.-government-funded, Arab-language news channel Alhurra.

It was April 12, and the email in the inbox of 500 of Alhurra’s employees was another move by the Trump administration and its Elon Musk-led Department of Government Efficiency to shut down U.S.-funded media initiatives abroad. Alhurra, which received around \$112 million in 2024 from Congress, joined other state-supported outlets, including Voice of America and Radio Free Europe/Radio Liberty, which had their funding frozen.

Done in DOGE’s chain-saw-signature style, the cuts have disrupted the lives of journalists both in Alhurra’s Middle Eastern bureaus and its Virginia headquarters, leaving them with no severance or compensation. Dozens who had permits to work in the U.S. are unsure if they can remain in America.

When news about Alhurra filtered out — along with talk that even MBN might shut down — many observers saw it as an own goal, a misguided rollback of U.S. soft power in the Middle East.

The Committee to Protect Journalists, which is helping MBN with legal representation to restore its funding, called the cutbacks “a betrayal of the U.S.’s historical commitment to press freedom.”

In a statement, Gedmin said, “Media in the Middle East thrive on a diet of anti-”

[See Alhurra, A4]

A prison gang’s line to the street

High school dropouts from ‘Klanheim’ era in O.C. acted as troops in white supremacist crimes in Southland.

By MATTHEW ORMSETH

Two men lay in a dark street in Pomona.

The gunshot wounds made clear how they died. Their tattoos offered clues about how they lived: Swastikas. Lightning bolts. Iron crosses. The words “Blood and Honor” and “Death Squad.”

The slain men were part of a white supremacist gang called Public Enemy Number 1, or PEN1. Prosecutors say they were killed in 2022 by members of their own crew, acting on orders from the Aryan Brotherhood, a syndicate with vast influ-



Orange County Superior Court

GANG member William Shoop tattooed his clavicle with the state’s penal code for a gang enhancement.

ence over white inmates in California prisons.

Founded 60 years ago at San Quentin, the Aryan Brotherhood has in recent years sought to evolve beyond a prison gang to take over rackets on the street, where PEN1 has served as its front line, according to testimony and court records reviewed by The Times.

Members of PEN1 have been convicted of robbing, extorting and killing for the Aryan Brotherhood, who are seen as the “superheroes” of the white criminal subculture, a longtime PEN1 member testified.

A group of no more than 35 men, the Aryan Brotherhood’s leaders were held for decades in solitary confinement at Pelican Bay, the maximum-security penitentiary near the Oregon border. Despite the state’s best efforts to isolate them, the gang’s leaders maintained

[See Gang, A6]

Voices MARK SWED MUSIC CRITIC

A musical innovator puts down his baton

Beloved conductor Michael Tilson Thomas takes his final bow at 80

SAN FRANCISCO — San Francisco Mayor Daniel Lurie had declared it Michael Tilson Thomas Day. City Hall glowed MTT’s trademark blue. Davies Symphony Hall, where Tilson Thomas presided over the San Francisco Symphony for an influential quarter-century, was festooned with giant blue balloons.

For Tilson Thomas, it all was the culmination of what he declared in February: “We all get to say the old show business expression, ‘It’s a wrap.’”

Despite starting treatment for an aggressive form of brain cancer in summer 2021, Tilson Thomas astonishingly continued to conduct throughout the U.S. and even in Europe for the next three and a half years. But in February he learned that the tumor had returned, and the conductor

[See Conductor, A10]



GINA FERAZZI Los Angeles Times

MICHAEL TILSON THOMAS, music director laureate of the San Francisco Symphony and mentee of Leonard Bernstein, makes his last stage appearance.

His appointment, announced Friday afternoon by the UC Board of Regents, comes at a tense time for the state’s vaunted system and elite universities nationwide, which are under attack by President Trump’s actions to purge higher education of what he derides as “woke” and “Marxist” ideologies, while also slashing federal support for medical and scientific research critical to the universities’ mission.

Milliken’s selection culminates a six-month search to replace UC President Michael V. Drake, who has been in his role since 2020 and will step down July 31.

UC is “universally regarded as the preeminent public research university in the world, and I am deeply honored to have an opportunity to join the many talented faculty, staff, and campus leaders in their vital work,” Milliken, who goes by “J.B.,” said in a statement. “It is more important than ever that we expand the education, research, health care, and public service for which UC is so widely admired and which has benefited so many Californians.”

Milliken, 68, has led large public university systems for more than 25 years, pivoting

[See Milliken, A12]

Nonprofit fix for an Altadena dilemma

The groups hope to limit gentrification as for-profit developers seek to build in city.

By ANDREW KHOURI

Eshale Williams always believed she’d eventually own the home she rented in Altadena’s historic Janes Village neighborhood.

The 1920s cottage was where she brought her son Brayden home from the hospital and where she held backyard parties for birthdays or whatever anniversary family and friends wanted to celebrate. Her mom lived a block away; her three sisters weren’t much further.

When the Eaton fire destroyed the house she called home for nearly 17 years, she received a proposal from the landlord. Williams said she was told she could have the burned lot if she could pay \$565,000, all cash, and close within 15 days.

“Nobody has \$565,000 in cash just right up front,” said Williams, a 47-year-old therapist and consultant said.

Since flames destroyed thousands of homes in largely middle-class Altadena in January, more than 80 prop-

[See Gentrification, A12]

Evers ‘not afraid’ of arrest threat

Wisconsin governor decries the president’s suggestion of detaining dissenters. **NATION, A5**

NPR, PBS fire back at Trump

The Corp. for Public Broadcasting says only Congress has a say in its funding. **BUSINESS, A9**

Alzheimer’s study faces budget cuts

White House derailing research on cruel brain diseases, Steve Lopez writes. **CALIFORNIA, B1**

Weather

Clouds may clear. L.A. Basin: 68/54. **B8**

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